when kept in the dark—doubling the time in which mosquitoes could bite them and pass on the virus.

Ill-effects on animals can have a knock-on effect on plants. When moths, which are attracted to light, are repeatedly drawn to artificial sources, not only can they be killed by exhaustion (because the light is never extinguished), or by the heat generated, but they also become more vulnerable to predators, which can spot them more easily.

The decline in moth numbers has a knock-on effect on the plants that they help pollinate, which then affects seed yield. In some places, seed yield has declined by as much as 30 percent. Researchers who studied a Swiss flower meadow under street lights found that nocturnal visits from pollinators declined by two-thirds.

“The solution is simple—turn off unnecessary lights, use only the amount of light needed for the task at hand, and shield all lighting so it shines down where it is needed.”

Tim Hunter